



John Gerard's 1597 *Herball* is one of the classic texts on healing plants.

dietary and lifestyle changes that will allow the body's self-regenerating powers—the modern equivalent of the “vital spirit”—to establish good health once again. Recovery may take longer than it would if treated with conventional medicine, but relief is generally enduring and free from side effects.

A patient with a stomach ulcer, for example, may be treated with a variety of herbs such as meadowsweet (*Filipendula ulmaria*, p. 98), German chamomile (*Chamomilla recutita*, p. 77), marshmallow (*Althaea officinalis*, p. 165), and deadly nightshade (*Atropa belladonna*, p. 69) to soothe inflammation, astringe, and protect the inner lining of the stomach, and reduce excess acid production. In addition, herbal practitioners also address

poor dietary habits, bad posture, and stress—which are all conditions that may have undermined the body's healing ability. Problems such as these are reversed with herbs to relieve stress, a diet rich in non-acidic vegetables and fruits, and exercise.

Popular Herbs

In European herbal medicine, native herbs are still highly popular. Alpine plants such as arnica (*Arnica montana*, p. 172) and pulsatilla (*Anemone pulsatilla*, p. 168) are much used in Swiss, German, Italian, and French herbal medicine, while comfrey (*Symphytum officinale*, p. 138) is particularly well liked in Britain. There has also been a surge in demand for exotic herbs. The Chinese ginkgo tree (*Ginkgo biloba*, p. 100), which improves circulation of blood to the head and helps the memory, is now cultivated in vast plantations in France, and has been a bestselling medicine in Germany for over 20 years.

European Traditions & the Future

Sales of over-the-counter herbal medicines in Europe have continued to increase over the last two decades, though the reasons for this growth vary widely.

It is possibly a reaction to the over-reliance on drug treatment in conventional medicine. Sound advice on a healthy diet and lifestyle, including food herbs, such as turmeric (*Curcuma longa*, p. 90), might well prove more beneficial than conventionally prescribed drugs in helping an aging population to stay healthy for longer.

Nevertheless, in several European countries herbal medicines are routinely prescribed, offering doctors a choice of gentle-acting treatments for chronic and more minor health problems. In Germany and Poland, herbal medicines can be frontline treatments for digestive disorders and chronic problems such as arthritis. This approach leaves conventional drug treatments available for more acute or serious conditions.

In contrast, a barely reported trend is that more and more people are growing medicinal plants. There seems to be a desire to rediscover the magic of cultivating and harvesting plants, and involving them (as food and medicine) in one's daily life.

Dried feverfew

Hawthorn (*Crataegus oxyacantha*, p. 87) has a marked tonic effect on the heart.

Dried hawthorn flowers and berries

Cowslip (*Primula veris*, p. 256) is a sedative plant that helps calm what herbalist John Gerard called “the frensies.”

Thyme (*Thymus vulgaris*, p. 143) is a good antiseptic and tonic herb. It is particularly effective as a treatment for chest infections.

Common foxglove (*Digitalis purpurea*, p. 202) is the source of digitalis, a widely used cardiac stimulant.

Heartsease (*Viola tricolor*, p. 282) gained its name from its former use in love potions. It is an effective expectorant, treating coughs and colds.

Lavender (*Lavandula officinalis*, p. 108) yields an essential oil that is a good first-aid remedy for insect bites and sunburn.